The Mind River

To Dr. Alan Love

He wanted once to measure rain,
to number drops on windowpane,
to trap the sky in labeled glass
and chart the hours as they pass.

He kept the leaves in ordered rows,
wrote Latin names for roots and boughs,
and thought that truth, like crystal light,
would settle clear if held just right.

He learned to weigh, to spin, divide,
to let the centrifuge decide;
to draw a line through scattered stars
and fence the wild in tidy bars.

But something in the turning wheel
refused the calm of cold anneal –
a whisper under metal's hum:
What makes a fact, what makes it come?

The river quickened. Sharp and fast,
his questions over granite passed –
If noise is noise, who names it so?
If models lead, where do they go?
Is law discovered in the stone,
or carved by hands we call our own?

The lab required a narrower sight –
a lantern fixed, a beam of light.
But he would lift it to the sky
and ask the circled darkness why.

"Fine thoughts," they said, "but not our sphere.
The pipette shakes when doubt draws near.
The grant prefers a tidy stream."
He nodded, shelved a careful dream.

The current slowed. Wide valley air.
Long grasses bending into prayer.
He walked beside the patient flow
where slower, deeper waters go.

He touched the margins of a page
and felt a different sort of gauge –
not weight of proof in numbered rows,
but weight of what the language shows.

Then sudden – cliff. The river's cry.
White thunder split the inward sky.
All measured lines in spray undone,
all tidy graphs unspooled, outrun.

He saw it then: the fall, the force –
not end of stream but change of course.
The water does not cease to be
when breaking into clarity.

He left the lab, its glass and steel,
the tempered bench, the ordered zeal.
He kept instead the restless art
of sounding depths beneath the chart.

Around the bend the valley spread –
blue distance, cedar, granite red.
The river steady in its scope,
yet never holding shape or slope.

He did not fail to test the real;
he turned to test the testing's keel.
Not how the molecules align,
but how we draw the knowing line.

For science narrows, keen and bright,
a blade that cleaves the day from night;
and he – he walked the wider seam
where meanings gather like a stream.

Still, sometimes in the dusk's soft air
he hears the spinning rotor there –
a ghost of hum, precise and thin,
a call to measure once again.

And like a river, quick then slow,
with falls that break and plains that flow,
his life runs on – uneven, clear –
through doubt made luminous, severe.

He could not dam the surging why,
Nor cage the thoughts that reach the sky.
So let the mountain rivers flow –
They seek the path they cannot know.